



FROM MEGA SCHEMES LIKE THE AMBEDKAR PARKS (BELOW) MAYAWATI IS NOW TURNING TO BASIC ISSUES, ESPECIALLY THOSE RELATING TO GIRLS

criminals". Whether it be over the sensational killing of an executive engineer by a BSP MLA at Auraiya in December and the crude manner in which the party leadership tried to cover for him or over the fielding of criminals and mafia in parliamentary elections, there is a wavering of BSP support among the upper castes.

To address this section, which is very crucial for Mayawati to cherish her dream of ruling the country from Delhi, the chief minister has in the last fortnight announced developmental schemes worth over Rs 5,000 crore with special focus on pilgrim cities. It is her strategy to counter the Congress's claim of being the only party "concerned with development and the common man". Mayawati may not have ever visited Ayodhya in Faizabad, but by plucking Vimlendra Mohan Pratap Mishra alias the Raja

As she has addressed her core constituency emotionally by building memorials and monuments at a cost of over Rs 2,000 crore, for the Brahmin-led upper castes she has mandated man Friday Satish Chand Mishra, who kicked off a series of Brahman Sammelans (conference of Brahmins) on February 9. He began his campaign from Amethi, the parliamentary constituency of the Gandhi scion Rahul Gandhi. Mishra will sell brand BSP among the upper castes once again and expects to reap the harvest this time too.

Taking Rahul head on, Mishra recently condemned him for bringing foreigners to his constituency for "poverty tourism" while addressing a Brahmin gathering. "Not only for the Brahmins but for the entire upper castes, the BSP has stood the test of time as they have been given a share in the party organisation and the state machinery. I feel this time Brahmins would vote for the BSP in a more decisive manner because unlike other parties who simply dupe the voters, Mayawati has fulfilled all promises regarding 'Sarvajan Hitaya, Sarvajan Sukhaya'," said Mishra. He added that Mayawati has forcefully pursued reservations in jobs for the upper caste poor too. Mayawati is also confident that after two decades of alleged neglect at the hands of other parties, the lure among the Brahmins for power sharing and acting as advisers to the ruler, would keep them in the BSP fold, at least till the present spell continues.

Unlike the previous regimes, the Mayawati and Mishra duo has been successful in integrating the two segments—scs and the upper castes—who have been hostile to each other since ages, both at the political and social level. There have been no caste riots, no war cry over misuse of the SC/ST Act against upper castes nor the incidents of land-grabbing by BSP cadres for erecting statues of Ambedkar on public and private lands. Whether Mayawati and Mishra, the faces of the Dalits and Brahmins respectively, will be able to do an encore is for time to tell. ■



Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

first time for any political party in 18 years. If the Assembly seats that the BSP won—206 out of 403—in 2007 vote for her party again then the BSP will rake in 40 of the total 80 Lok Sabha seats in the state.

Things have, however, changed since then. Mayawati has not been able to contain the spiralling crime graph and her wayward MLAs and ministers have brought disrepute to her Government. By recruiting mafia dons and criminals she has allowed herself to be perceived as "soft on

of Ayodhya as the BSP candidate from Faizabad, she has adopted Ayodhya and has announced a complete facelift of the temple town. So is the case with Vrindavan in Mathura, Varanasi and Bithoor in Kanpur, which no other government did in the past. She has pressed the state machinery to implement developmental works in these cities at full speed and has assigned her Cabinet Secretary Shashank Shekhar Singh and state Chief Secretary Atul Gupta to review the work and report to her.

ON THE UPPER CASTES WHO SCRIPTED HER 2007 VICTORY.